

OLD-SCHOOL ESSENTIALS

Notes on the 2026 Update

Version May 2026

About This Document

Prior to 2026, *Old-School Essentials* (OSE) was published in several forms: the *Classic Fantasy Rules Tome*, the *Classic Game Set*, the *Advanced Fantasy Player's + Referee's Tomes*, and the *Advanced Expansion Set*. From 2026 onwards, OSE exists in a single definitive form consisting of two core books: the *Player's Book* and *Referee's Book*.

In addition to combining all material from the prior versions of the game, the 2026 core books include a number of clarifications, minor rules fixes, and new optional rules. This document summarizes the most significant changes for players with prior versions of OSE to use in their games, if desired.

The 2026 core books also include expanded introductory material, expanded indexes, extensive additional examples of play, and many new illustrations. These elements are not reproduced here.

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NEW OPTIONAL RULES

Advanced Hit Dice

The default HD types of classes are based on *B/X*. Some classes list an optional higher HD type based on *AD&D*. Using these increases character survivability.

Advanced Hit Dice

- ▶ **Acrobat:** 1d6.
- ▶ **Assassin:** 1d6.
- ▶ **Barbarian:** 1d10.
- ▶ **Bard:** No change (1d6).
- ▶ **Cleric:** 1d8.
- ▶ **Druid:** 1d8.
- ▶ **Fighter:** 1d10.
- ▶ **Illusionist:** No change (1d4).
- ▶ **Knight:** 1d10.
- ▶ **Magic-user:** No change (1d4).
- ▶ **Paladin:** 1d10.
- ▶ **Ranger:** 1d10.
- ▶ **Thief:** 1d6.

Demihuman Class Advanced Hit Dice

- ▶ **Drow:** 1d8.
- ▶ **Duergar:** 1d8.
- ▶ **Dwarf:** 1d10.
- ▶ **Elf:** 1d8.
- ▶ **Gnome:** 1d6.
- ▶ **Half-elf:** 1d8.
- ▶ **Halfling:** No change (1d6).
- ▶ **Half-orc:** 1d8.
- ▶ **Svirfneblin:** No change (1d6).

Age and Lifespan

Instead of each player choosing their character's age when starting play (at 1st level), this may be randomly determined. The referee may also secretly roll for their eventual lifespan.

Age and Lifespan

Race	Starting Age	Lifespan
Drow	100 + 5d6	450 + 4d100
Duergar	40 + 5d6	250 + 2d100
Dwarf	40 + 5d6	250 + 2d100
Elf	100 + 5d6	350 + 4d100
Gnome	60 + 3d12	200 + 3d100
Half-elf	15 + 1d6	125 + 3d20
Halfling	20 + 3d4	100 + 1d100
Half-orc	15 + 1d4	70 + 2d20
Human	15 + 1d4	90 + 2d20
Svirfneblin	60 + 3d12	200 + 3d100

Attacking When Blinded

Instead of being unable to attack, blinded characters suffer a -4 penalty to attack rolls, saves, and AC.

Fighter Combat Dominance

Against foes of less than 1 Hit Die (e.g. normal humans, 1-1 HD monsters, etc.), a fighter of 2nd level or higher can make one melee attack per round per level. For example, a 5th level fighter could make 5 melee attacks per round against such foes.

Hovering at Death's Door

Groups wishing to increase PC survivability may rule that damage reducing a character to 0hp or as low as -3hp renders them unconscious, not dead.

Unconsciousness: The unconscious character loses 1hp per round. If they reach -10hp, the character dies.

Binding wounds: If an ally spends a round binding the character's wounds, they stop losing 1hp every round and regain consciousness 1d6 Turns later with 1hp. The character remains weak—see *After Being Revived*.

Magical healing: Awakens the character with 1hp. The character remains weak—see *After Being Revived*.

After being revived: Returning from death's door is an ordeal. Until the character gets two full weeks of bed rest, they have 1 hit point, move at half the normal rate, cannot carry heavy items, and cannot attack, cast spells, or use other class abilities. Recovery from this weakness cannot be hastened by magic of any kind.

Increasing Back-Stab Damage

Back-stab attacks optionally inflict triple damage at 6th–10th level and quadruple damage at 11th level and above.

This optional rule applies to the thief class, the half-orc demihuman class, and the assassin's assassination attack (see p7).

Magic Armour Size

If the referee wishes, each suit of magic armour is sized to fit characters of certain stature, as rolled on the following table.

Magic Armour Size

d20	Armour Size
1–13	Human (including half-elves and half-orcs)
14–17	Elf (including drow)
18–19	Dwarf (including duergars)
20	Halfling or gnome (including svirfneblins)

Magic Swords and Daggers Shedding Light

If the referee wishes, magic swords shed light in a 15' radius when unsheathed and daggers in a 10' radius.

No Alignment Languages

The existence and functioning of alignment languages require cosmological justification, which does not suit all campaigns. Groups preferring to play without alignment languages can simply drop them. This places slightly more importance on PCs knowing other languages, but does not significantly alter the game.

Training

The referee may require characters to engage in a period of training in order to level up. This can act as a gold sink, reducing the amount of cash available to PCs. Until the training is complete, the character cannot advance to the next level and can gain no further XP.

Training with a mentor: A character can train under a mentor of the same class and higher level. Training requires 1–4 weeks. The referee may determine the training time randomly (1d4) or may base it on the player's performance (e.g. clever play and successful use of class abilities entail a shorter training time). Training under a mentor costs 400gp per week per level of the trainee (calculated using the trainee's *current* level, not the level to be advanced to).

Training alone: If the character trains alone, the cost is halved but the time required is doubled.

Weapon Restrictions For Small Characters

An example list of weapons allowed to small characters is provided, as follows. Small races such as gnomes, halflings, and svirfneblins can only use weapons appropriate to their stature. The referee must determine which weapons this includes. The following list is provided as an example: club, crossbow, dagger, hand axe, javelin, mace, short bow, short sword, sling, spear, staff, sword (must be wielded two-handed), war hammer.

XP For Magic Items

Referees wishing to increase characters' rate of advancement may also grant XP for magic items gained by adventuring. The XP value of each type of magic item is as follows. The value of magic armour and weapons is based on the number of "pluses"—for example, a *shield +1* grants 250 XP and a *shield +2* grants 500 XP.

- ▶ **Ammunition:** 25 XP per plus (per individual piece of ammunition).
- ▶ **Chain mail:** 600 XP per plus.
- ▶ **Leather armour:** 300 XP per plus.
- ▶ **Miscellaneous item:** 2,000 XP.
- ▶ **Plate mail:** 900 XP per plus.
- ▶ **Potion:** 250 XP.
- ▶ **Protection scroll:** 1,000 XP.
- ▶ **Ring:** 2,000 XP.
- ▶ **Rod:** 4,000 XP.
- ▶ **Shield:** 250 XP per plus.
- ▶ **Spell scroll:** 100 XP per spell level.
- ▶ **Staff:** 5,000 XP.
- ▶ **Sword:** 500 XP per plus.
- ▶ **Wand:** 3,000 XP.
- ▶ **Weapon:** 500 XP per plus.

Selling magic items: If players sell a magic item rather than keeping and making use of it, the referee may instead grant XP at a rate of 1 XP per gp sale value.

RULES ADDITIONS

Combat Aptitude

Character classes are now listed with an additional game statistic: combat aptitude. Combat aptitude is the rate at which the character's attack and saving throw values improve:

- ▶ **Martial:** Every 3 levels.
- ▶ **Semi-martial:** Every 4 levels.
- ▶ **Non-martial:** Every 5 levels.

Poison Antidotes

It may also be possible to purchase antidotes doses for each type of poison. These cost the same as a dose of the poison and completely negate the effects of the poison if used within the onset time (the same round for instant onset poisons).

Spell Caster Specialist

Based on mentions in the *B/X* rules, a new type of specialist is listed that PCs can hire, as follows.

High-level NPCs willing to cast spells (e.g. *remove curse*, *raise dead*) in return for payment, completion of a quest, or both.

Casting spells: The referee decides the cost, based on the spell required and PCs' relationship with the NPC. The referee might base the cost on the spell's level, for example: 1st: 100gp, 2nd: 250gp, 3rd: 500gp, 4th: 1,000gp, 5th: 2,500gp, 6th: 5,000gp. Spells for illegal or morally dubious ends might cost double or more.

Identifying magic items: High-level NPC magic-users may also be able to identify magic items. The process takes time: possibly several weeks.

CLARIFICATIONS

Air Elemental

The ability to sweep aside low HD foes has been clarified, as follows. (This also applies to the tornado effect of the *control weather* spell.)

Creatures under 2 HD hit by the elemental must **save versus death** or be swept aside and killed.

Green Slime

The green slime monster's ability to dissolve clothing armour has been clarified, as follows.

A victim whom green slime drops on (or who steps in it) has 6 rounds to remove the slime as it dissolves their clothing and armour. After 6 rounds, the slime sticks to the victim's flesh and turns them into green slime in 1d4 rounds.

Stun

The stun ability possessed by a small number of monsters and magic items (e.g. catoblepas, bull shark, water termite) has been clarified as: ½ move, -2 AC, unable to act.

RULES CHANGES

Attacking From Behind

The rule for attacks from behind has been updated, as follows, for fidelity with the *B/X* rules.

+2 bonus to attack rolls; AC bonus from defender's shield (if any) negated.

Multiple Classes

This option is now explicitly limited to demihumans. Elves (including drow) can choose 2 or 3 classes; other demihumans can choose 2 classes.

Disallowed Class Combinations

Classes of similar function cannot be combined, as follows:

- **Arcane spell casters:** Illusionist and magic-user cannot be combined.
- **Divine spell casters:** Bard, cleric, druid, paladin, and ranger cannot be combined. For example, a bard/cleric is disallowed.
- **Stealth-using classes:** Acrobat, assassin, and thief cannot be combined. For example, an assassin/thief is disallowed.
- **Warriors:** Barbarian, fighter, knight, paladin, and ranger cannot be combined. For example, a fighter/paladin is disallowed.

Secondary Skills

The list of secondary skills (an optional rule) has been slightly altered.

Secondary Skills

d100	Secondary Skill
01–02	Armourer
03–04	Bowyer / fletcher
05–07	Carpenter
08–13	Farmer

d100	Secondary Skill
14–17	Fisher
18–23	Forester
24–26	Gambler
27–30	Groom
31–35	Hunter
36–37	Jeweller
38–40	Leatherworker
41–42	Limner / painter
43–45	Mason
46–47	Miner
48–49	Navigator
50–52	Sailor
53–54	Scribe
55–56	Shipwright
57–59	Tailor / weaver
60–62	Teamster
63–65	Trader
66–69	Trapper
70–71	Weaponsmith
72–85	No skill of use
86–100	Roll for two skills

Slow Weapons

The Slow weapon quality is now optional.

Waterborne Adventuring

The chance of encounters at sea has been altered, for fidelity with the *B/X* rules.

At sea, an encounter check roll of 2 results in a land-based encounter if the ship docks, or no encounter otherwise.

Wilderness Adventuring

The mechanics for roads and trails have been revised based on a new reading of the rules in *B/X*, as follows.

A trail allows characters to travel at normal speed through any terrain, and a road at 1½ times normal speed (50% faster) through any terrain.

ADVANCED CLASS CHANGES

Assassin

Assassination

The assassin class's assassination ability can now be used on any target (not just persons), as follows.

When attacking an unaware opponent from behind, an assassin receives a +4 bonus to hit and doubles any damage dealt. If the attack succeeds on a person, they must also **save versus death** or die, with a penalty based on the assassin's level (AS in the table opposite).

Manufacturing Poisons

From 9th level, assassins can brew poison doses, requiring 1 day per 100gp value and costing half normal price.

Barbarian

Fear of Magic

This restriction is reworked as follows.

Barbarians are mistrustful of magic and refuse to use magic items or come under the influence of spells. As the character gains experience, this restriction relaxes:

- ▶ **2nd level:** May receive divine spells.
- ▶ **3rd level:** May use potions.
- ▶ **4th level:** May use magic weapons.
- ▶ **5th level:** May use magic armour.
- ▶ **6th level:** May receive arcane spells.
- ▶ **8th level:** May use any magic item.

Strike Invulnerable Monsters

Barbarians no longer have this ability (but may now use magic weapons from 4th level).

Knight

The wording around the code of chivalry and engaging the most powerful foe has been reworked as follows.

Knights are bound by a code of honour with the following precepts, which they strive to uphold in all their deeds.

Service: A knight should loyally carry out the orders of their liege.

Social hierarchy: A knight should honour superiors, respect equals, demand obedience from inferiors, and scorn the ignoble.

Defence: A knight should defend any in their charge to the death.

Prowess of arms: A knight should always favour the most impressive-looking armour available.

Battle: When an encounter turns to combat, a knight should engage the most powerful or worthy foe.

Dishonourable Deeds

A knight does not earn XP for deeds performed at odds with any precepts of the code (as judged by the referee).

If a knight brings serious dishonour upon themselves or their liege (this may include changing alignment) they may have their knighthood revoked. The character becomes a fighter of equivalent level. It may be possible to regain the status of knighthood by performing a special quest.

Ranger

The ranger has a new giant slayer ability, as follows.

Rangers receive a +1 bonus to attack and damage rolls made against giants and related creatures (e.g. ogres and trolls). This increases to +2 from 4th–8th level and +3 at 9th level and above. In campaigns where giants do not commonly threaten rangers' lands, the referee may specify another type of enemy instead.